CASE STUDY

ONCORE & proprioception

A case study in neurodiverse swim instruction

LEARNER Elijah, 5 years old	DATE PREPARED 3 September 2026 · updated 4 October 2026
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Elijah with Connor and ONCORE at Darren Lange Swimming Academy.

Executive summary

Elijah is a 5-year-old swimmer with coordination delays. He could not do single-side breathing in freestyle without a kickboard. Without that support, he would panic, inhale water, and need his teacher to step in.

Connor introduced ONCORE in a group class on 15 July 2026. When it was removed, Elijah panicked mid-lap, and the session ended in a meltdown. During a break in lessons while Connor was on leave, Elijah fractured his wrist. Lessons then moved to a private 1:1 format from 25 August 2026. Confidence and enjoyment of the water came first, with technical correction to follow. By the third session, on 1 September, his technique with ONCORE had improved substantially. The remaining challenge was coordinating the timing of his breathing with his body's movement, not the physical pattern itself.

In the fourth session, on 8 September, Elijah described the problem in his own words: he could not feel where his body was, and he was scared of drinking water. Connor responded by asking Elijah to trust in him and his teachings first. Elijah then completed four repeats of the side-breathing drill without ONCORE and without inhaling water.

The fifth session, on 15 September, ran the same drills and the same process, with two things changed at once: the work moved to the deep end, and the swim distance went from 8 metres to 12.5 metres. Elijah was distracted and nervous throughout, and looked for Connor during every drill and every swim. The distance was what he fixed on. He still completed the side-breathing work, but this time he needed only a gentle reminder of the

Session 4 conversation rather than the conversation itself. Changing both things in the one lesson is the part Connor would do differently.

The sixth session, on 29 September, took the distance back down to 8 metres. Elijah's body position and kick were strong and rolling to breathe was fine, but once ONCORE came off, his technique and timing fell away again, with no clear reason on the day. Pressed on why, Elijah said he is not good at it. Connor would not let that stand. After the lesson, he and Elijah's mother agreed to change course and teach breaststroke first.

> OUTCOME AND IMPACT
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> What looked like a purely technical fix turned out to be something else. The skill had been building across the earlier sessions with ONCORE, and on the day, fear was what held it back. What Elijah needed was enough trust in his teacher to use it. In Session 5, in harder conditions, a short reminder was enough to get him started — where a week earlier it took the whole conversation.

Learner background

Age	5 years old
Diagnosis	Coordination delays
Lesson format	1:1 private lessons, 30 minutes. Moved from a group class after the 15 July 2026 session.
Time with DLSA and this teacher	Taught by Connor since Elijah was almost 4, across 4 levels of the DLSA program. Connor has also taught Elijah's brother, across 7 levels.

The challenge

Elijah's main difficulty was single-side breathing in freestyle, which he could not yet do without a kickboard. Without that support, he would panic, inhale water, and need his teacher's help to recover.

Elijah's mother has shared that he struggles with coordination more broadly, and that this affects his confidence.

> **“I just don't feel where my body is at. I'm scared I'll drink water.”**
>
> ELIJAH · SESSION 4, 8 SEPTEMBER 2026

In Session 4, Elijah put the problem into his own words. This is the core reason Connor has been using ONCORE: to help him feel where his arms are and when his breath happens. These are Elijah's words, not a clinical assessment. Connor also raised with Elijah's mother that Elijah could simply be a 5-year-old trying to avoid swimming correctly (see Session 4).

The approach: ONCORE

Disclosure: Since hearing of Connor's findings and work in this space, Jade Edmistone, Managing Director of Get Oncore Pty Ltd, gifted the ONCORE used in these lessons and offered an affiliate link for their products. The link was not active at the time of printing. Connor is not paid for this case study.

ONCORE® is a skill acquisition tool made from low-density foam with a textured surface. The ONCORE Academy says the texture stimulates tactile receptors and gives swimmers immediate feedback on arm position, core engagement and body alignment in the water.

They market ONCORE as supporting proprioception — the body's sense of where it is and how it is moving — and “water feel” for swimmers of all levels.

Connor introduced ONCORE to give Elijah a physical anchor for his arm position while he worked on breathing, so the support did not depend on him managing the coordination and timing on his own. In the third session, BAND IT was added to help him hold ONCORE securely, because holding it was itself a coordination barrier. By the fourth session, Elijah no longer needed BAND IT and could keep ONCORE balanced during the drills.

Implementation

SESSION 1 **15 July 2026 · group class**

Observations

- Worked well with ONCORE while using it.

- Once ONCORE was removed, he panicked mid-lap. With verbal reassurance he completed the lap, but with poor technique and without an effective breath.
- Near the end of the lesson he had a meltdown, with full-body sobs, and told Connor, “I'm not good enough for this.”
- Connor held him through the rest of the lesson while the other swimmers completed their return laps. Elijah did not swim again that session, but joined in “sinky toys” at the end.

Connor then went on leave, during which Elijah fractured his wrist. When Connor returned, he and Elijah's mother agreed to move to private 1:1 lessons, to help Elijah rebuild his confidence and enjoyment of the water before going back to technical correction.

SESSION 2 **25 August 2026 · private lesson, 30 minutes**

First lesson back, over a month after Session 1.

Drill progression

- Superman kicking.
- One arm forward, one arm back, kicking and rotating to breathe.
- Freestyle on the kickboard.

Observations

- Struggled with ONCORE, and struggled again once the kickboard was removed.
- Given the context, Connor put enjoyment ahead of technical progress in this lesson.

SESSION 3 **1 September 2026 · private lesson, 30 minutes**

Observations

- Performed drills with ONCORE much better than in the previous session.
- BAND IT was introduced to help him hold ONCORE with more security.
- Technique was no longer the main barrier. The remaining challenge was coordinating the timing of his breathing with his body's movement.
- Good progress overall.

SESSION 4 **8 September 2026 · private lesson, 30 minutes**



Session 4 — working the side-breathing drill with ONCORE, before it was removed.

Side breathing with ONCORE removed (shallow end)

- This part of the lesson was in the shallow end, so Connor could catch any stopping without it turning into a panic.
- As soon as ONCORE was removed, Elijah kept stopping after his first attempt at breathing to the side. Connor let this go three times. Each time, he encouraged Elijah and reinforced “no negative talk, you can do this”.
- On the fourth stop, Connor addressed it head-on. Elijah became emotional and said, “I just don't feel where my body is at. I'm scared I'll drink water.”
- Connor knew Elijah would not be able to trust in himself, as this was the first time he had put this fear into words, so he worked on getting Elijah to trust him instead: “Would I let you drink water?”, “Would I teach you how to do it wrong?”, “Would I ever let you get hurt when you're with me?” Elijah answered each with confidence: “No, you help me.” Connor ended the conversation with, “OK then, trust what I've taught you to do and trust your body to do it.”
- Elijah then did four repeats of the side-breathing drill. His technique was not perfect, but he did not inhale water once. When he realised what he had done, his smile was huge, and there were lots of celebrations from both of them.

IMPORTANT TO NOTE

The conversation was short, but the trust behind it was not. Connor has taught Elijah since he was almost 4, across 4 levels of the DLSA program, and the skill had been building over three sessions with ONCORE. On the day, fear was what held it back. The emotional connection is what let Connor show Elijah his true potential.

Jump ins and back float (deep end)

- The lesson finished with jump ins in the deep end: jump in, float on his back, and return to the edge.
- He had a small panic during a back float before returning to the edge. When Connor talked with him about it, Elijah said, “I don't know how to float.” Connor replied in a joking tone, “What? But I'm the one who taught you how to do that, you can't have forgotten!” and Elijah laughed.
- Then, in a serious tone, Connor repeated the reassurances from earlier in the lesson: “Would I teach you the wrong thing? Would I ever let you get hurt? Yes, you're floating, but I'm still right here. Trust me and yourself for 5 seconds.” Elijah floated successfully and got lots of praise.
- He did about four jumps, with only one slightly panicked return to the wall. Connor addressed it, talked through what he should have done, and included reassurance.
- For his final jump, Elijah asked to jump from the block instead of the pool edge. Connor was very nervous for him but said yes, because Elijah was leading it. Elijah jumped in, floated on his back for 5 seconds, returned to the wall and pulled himself out, which ended the lesson. His smile was enormous, and it was still there after he waited for Connor to get out and walk him back to his mother.

Parent communication

- After the lesson, Connor gave Elijah's mother a quick update. He told her that Elijah had been able to put the issue into words, and explained the tactic he had taken in response.
- Because Connor is not a medical professional, he added a disclaimer: Elijah could simply be a 5-year-old trying to avoid swimming correctly. They agreed to treat it as information to be aware of as they continue to help Elijah.

SESSION 5 — 15 September 2026 · private lesson, 30 minutes

Same drills and same process as Session 4. Two things changed in the one lesson: the work moved to the deep end, and the swim distance went from 8 metres, which Elijah had been swimming in the earlier sessions, to 12.5 metres.

Observations

- Distracted and nervous for the whole lesson.
- Looked for Connor during every drill and every swim, rather than getting on with the work as he had in Session 4.
- Fixed on the distance. The 12.5 metres was “too far”, and that became the thing he got stuck on — more than the depth.

- Completed the side-breathing work. He needed a gentle reminder of the Session 4 conversation to get there, rather than the conversation itself.

> **WHAT I WOULD DO DIFFERENTLY**
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> Move to the deep end, or add the distance, but not both in the one lesson. The deep end was the change worth making. The extra 4.5 metres gave Elijah something concrete to argue with, and once “too far” was in his head it took over the session. He got the work done in the end, but neither change got a fair test, and I lost a clean read on what the deep end on its own would have looked like.

SESSION 6 **29 September 2026 · private lesson, 30 minutes**

Distance back down to 8 metres. Freestyle drills as normal.

Observations

- Body position for the kick was great.
- Rolling to breathe was okay.
- Once ONCORE was removed, technique and timing regressed. No clear reason for it on the day.

Getting to the real answer

- Connor kept pressing past “I don't know” and “Cause”, to push Elijah into thinking about it properly and to give him room to trust Connor with the real answer.
- Elijah eventually gave an answer along the lines of, “Because I'm not good at it.”
- Connor stopped it there: “Nope, not it. We do not say that about ourselves. You haven't learnt it properly yet, so it's not fair to say that at all.”

CHANGE OF PLAN: BREASTSTROKE FIRST

After that answer, and with his mother's agreement, I am teaching Elijah breaststroke first.

What I am after is the belief, before the stroke. If his breaststroke comes along and “I'm not good at it” is still there the next time something gets hard, I have not fixed the thing that matters. The stroke is how I get at it: I want him to own one thing in the water completely, so he has his own evidence to argue with instead of mine.

Breaststroke, because it is already his. When he panics, his legs go to a breaststroke kick on their own, without being asked. It is the closest thing he has to something he does not have to think about, so it is the shortest route to a stroke he can finish.

Freestyle stays in, in small doses. He has built a good kick and body position and I am not giving that up. It is just no longer what the lesson is about. ONCORE comes with us for the breaststroke kick, as a solid anchor for his front end while he holds his body position.

I will know it is working when he asks. The day he volunteers to go back to freestyle, or to try something harder, the same way he asked to jump from the block in Session 4, the confidence is his rather than mine.

Results

In Session 1, Elijah panicked when ONCORE was removed. By Session 3, he was performing much better with ONCORE, and the remaining challenge had narrowed to coordinating the timing of his breathing with his body's movement, not his technique. In Session 4, he completed four repeats of the side-breathing drill without ONCORE and without inhaling water — the first time this happened in any logged session. He finished that lesson by choosing to jump in from the block, float on his back for 5 seconds and return to the wall. The move to private 1:1 lessons after Session 1, and the focus on confidence and enjoyment before technical correction, appear to have supported this progress.

Session 5 held that ground rather than building on it. The same drills and the same process ran with two conditions changed at once: the deep end, and a swim distance lifted from 8 to 12.5 metres. Elijah spent the lesson distracted, nervous and checking for his teacher during every drill and every swim, and fixed on the new distance as too far. He completed the side-breathing work, but needed a gentle reminder of the Session 4 conversation to do it. That is

a lighter prompt than Session 4 required, which is the direction this should travel, and it held up under two conditions he had not met before.

Session 6 put the distance back to 8 metres. The kick and the body position held, but the side-breathing timing came apart again as soon as ONCORE was removed, and there was no clear cause for it on the day. What the lesson did produce was the reason underneath: Elijah said he is not good at it. That is a belief about himself rather than a fault in the drill, and it is what the move to breaststroke is aimed at.

Discussion

Initially, I felt Elijah's issue was purely technical. He taught me something along this journey too.

ONCORE was vital. It gave him a way to feel himself in the water, which is exactly what he was missing. But for Elijah, ONCORE on its own was not enough. In his case, getting past the fear took someone he could connect with emotionally. He needed to be pushed by someone he trusted, so he could see how good he already was, as long as he trusted his body to do the work.

The conversation in Session 4 was short, but it drew on everything that came before it. I've taught Elijah since he was almost 4, so when I asked, “Would I ever let you get hurt when you're with me?”, he already had his answer.

Session 5 is the honest other half of that. I changed two things at once — the deep end and the distance — and he spent the lesson looking for me instead of swimming. He got there in the end, and a gentle reminder was enough where a week earlier it took the whole conversation, so the Session 4 work is holding. But the extra 4.5 metres gave him something concrete to fix on, and “too far” took over the session. In hindsight, the deep end was the change worth making on its own. Bandura's point, in the limits below, is the one I would hold onto here: confidence built on encouragement stays fragile until the learner's own success backs it up. Elijah is starting to bank that success. He needed less of me this time to reach it.

Session 6 told me more than the swimming did. The distance was back to 8 metres and the kick looked good, so the regression once ONCORE came off was not about the conditions. Pushing past “I don't know” is uncomfortable, but it is where the useful answer lives, and what came back was “I'm not good at it”. You cannot drill that away. So I am starting again from the stroke he already trusts: when he panics, his legs go to breaststroke on their own. Building confidence there first, with his mother's agreement, gives him something he knows he can do before we return to the rest.

What the research says

Research on fear, trust and motor learning helps explain what happened in Session 4. It cannot prove what caused Elijah's result, but it does suggest why the conversation worked. Each row links a moment from the lessons to the research behind it.

WHAT HAPPENED WITH ELIJAH	WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS
Fear stopped the drill Once ONCORE was removed, Elijah kept stopping and said he was scared he would drink water.	Fear can pull performance below what a learner is able to do. Bandura (1977) noted that high levels of fear or tension usually make performance worse, and attentional control theory explains one reason: anxiety draws attention away from the task and towards the threat (Eysenck et al., 2007). In children with developmental coordination disorder (DCD), anxiety has been linked to underestimating their own ability and to changes in how they move on harder tasks (Harris et al., 2022). Elijah's record says coordination delays, not DCD, so this applies by analogy only.
Trust made the encouragement land “Would I ever let you get hurt when you're with me?” “No, you help me.”	Encouragement from another person is one of the ways a learner comes to believe they can succeed. Bandura (1977) argued that its effect can vary a great deal depending on how credible, trustworthy and expert the learner sees that person to be.
A relationship built over time Connor has taught Elijah since he was almost 4, across 4 levels of the DLSA program.	For young children, a teacher can act as a safe haven and a secure base, and teacher sensitivity is central to that relationship (Verschueren & Koomen, 2012). A meta-analysis of classroom studies linked close teacher–student relationships with higher engagement and achievement (Roorda et al., 2011). These studies show an association, not cause, and they come from classrooms, not pools.
A trusted adult close by “Yes, you're floating, but I'm still right here. Trust me and yourself for 5 seconds.”	The presence of a trusted adult can dampen a child's stress response, a process called social buffering (Hostinar et al., 2014). Most of this evidence involves parents, not teachers.

Planning for fear in the water

The drill without ONCORE started in the shallow end, so Connor could catch any stopping before it became a panic.

A small qualitative study of swimming lessons found that fear of the water gets in the way of learning to swim, and that the instructor plays a central part in helping learners feel secure (Coelho et al., 2025).

Elijah chose the block jump

For his final jump, Elijah asked to jump from the block, and Connor said yes because Elijah was leading it.

OPTIMAL theory proposes that giving learners some control, and raising their expectation of success, improves motor performance and learning (Wulf & Lewthwaite, 2016).

A 2024 review of 166 experiments found that few of them measured motivation at all, so the theory's claims about motivation are not yet well supported (Parma et al., 2024).

Two changes at once

Session 5 moved to the deep end and lifted the distance from 8 to 12.5 metres in the same lesson. Elijah was nervous, checked for his teacher constantly and fixed on the distance, though he completed the work after a gentle reminder.

This is Connor's own read, not a finding. The research above offers one angle on it: if anxiety draws attention towards the threat and away from the task (Eysenck et al., 2007), then a second new condition gives a fearful learner one more thing to attend to instead of the skill.

Bandura (1977) also holds here — confidence built through encouragement is fragile until the learner's own success backs it up. A lighter prompt in Session 5 is what that backing looks like early on.

LIMITS OF THIS EVIDENCE

Elijah is one learner across six logged sessions, and other things changed over that time: three sessions of work with ONCORE, the move to 1:1 lessons, the shallow-end set-up in Session 4, the deep end and longer distance in Session 5, and the return to 8 metres in Session 6. The research explains why the conversation may have worked. It cannot show that the conversation alone caused the result.

Bandura (1977) also noted that confidence built through encouragement is fragile until the learner's own success backs it up. Session 5 is a first sign of that backing: Elijah repeated the work on a gentle reminder rather than the full conversation, under two conditions that were new to him. It is one session, and the real test is still a lesson where he does it with no prompt at all.

Practical takeaways for teachers

Don't be afraid of the emotional connection

Within appropriate professional limits, of course. Some learners have all the technique they need and are still waiting for a reason to trust themselves, or to trust you. That trust is built lesson by lesson, well before you need to call on it.

Change one thing at a time

New depth, new distance, new drill: pick one. A learner who is working on confidence will find the second change and argue with it, and you lose the read on both. Session 5 cost me a lesson to learn that.

Find the tools that complement your teaching

ONCORE has been vital to my continued success with learners who struggle with sensory input and coordination. Find the equipment that supports the way you teach, and learn it properly.

Check the breakthrough holds

One good lesson is a start. Look for the skill again in the next session, without the same pep talk, before you count it as learned. A smaller prompt each time is the progress you want; no prompt at all is the finish line.

Keep the goal in mind

This learner will succeed. The question is only what you need to do to make sure that happens.

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Consent & media notes

Media included: three photos of Elijah and Connor with ONCORE.

Written parental consent is on file for use of Elijah's first name and the photographs in this case study and the accompanying slides, per DLSA case study conventions.

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